

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week 3: Lesson 1



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Week 3



This week the focus is on structure and argumentation.



Essay Structure



- There are many ways of structuring an essay.
- The essay question for Week 1 was: “Last year 3.96 billion people used social media, which is more than half the world’s population. Is this cause for concern?”
- How did you structure your essay? Are you happy with the structure you used, or could you have improved it?
- Look at potential structures on the following slides. Which one is closest to the one you used?

Structure A: Justification



1. Claim

1. Reason 1

1. Reason 2

1. Reason 3

1. Restatement of claim

- This structure allows a clear argument.
- BUT the argument is one-sided; it doesn't show an understanding of the debate;
- In social science essays, the essay is rarely 'black and white'; the answer is often 'it depends'.
- This structure is improved if each reason includes an acknowledgment of possible weaknesses/alternative arguments.

Structure B: Rebuttal

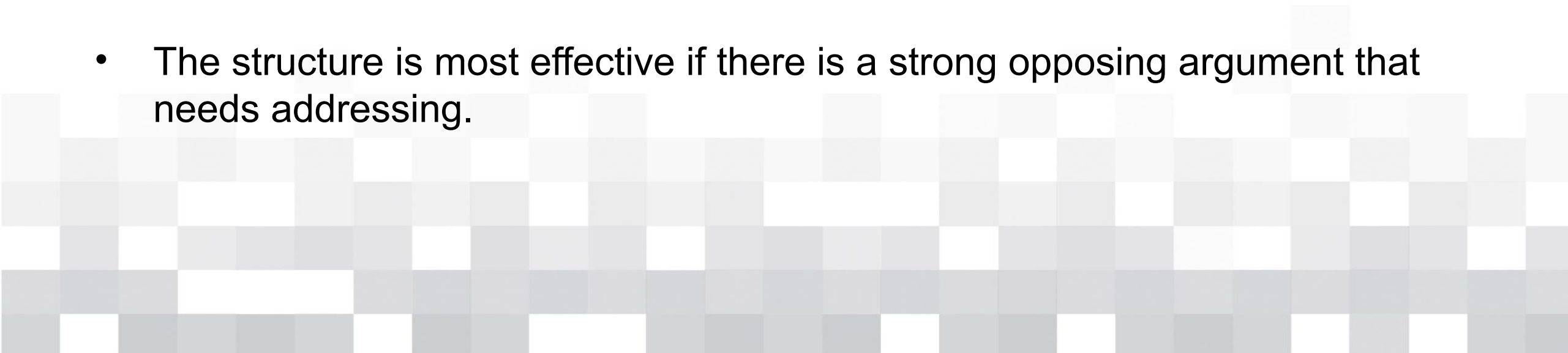


1. Claim

1. Counter-claim

1. Rebuttal

1. Restatement of claim

- This structure engages directly with opposing views and shows evaluation rather than description.
 - BUT students may spend too much time explaining the opposing view.
 - AND weak rebuttals make the essay unconvincing.
 - The structure is most effective if there is a strong opposing argument that needs addressing.
- 
- A decorative checkerboard pattern of light and dark gray squares covers the bottom third of the slide.

Structure C: Synthesis



1. Claim

1. Position A

1. Position B

1. Synthesis

1. Restatement of claim

- This structure shows an understanding of the debate and reflects the complexity of real-world issues
- BUT the position may not always be clear; students sometimes sit on the fence.
- AND when outlining Position A and Position B, the essay may be descriptive rather than argumentative/analytical.
- The structure is improved if 'Position A' and 'Position B' are evaluated, not just described.

Structure D: Thematic



1. Claim

1. Theme 1

1. Theme 2

1. Theme 3

1. Restatement of claim

- This structure shows an understanding of the debate while still providing an answer to the question AND allows a nuanced answer i.e. 'it depends' rather than 'yes' or 'no'.
- BUT planning an essay with this structure is likely to be more time-consuming AND the argument can become fragmented; students may discuss themes separately without linking them to the central question.
- This structure usually works better for longer coursework essays than shorter timed essays.

Last year 3.96 billion people used social media, which is more than half the world's population. Is this cause for concern?

- Using Week 1's essay question, create 4 essay plans to reflect each essay structure (justification, rebuttal, synthesis & thematic)
- Which structure do you like best for this essay and why?

Paragraphs



A good paragraph is a mini essay. It should demonstrate three components:

Introduction, i.e., a topic sentence

Body, i.e., supporting details

Conclusion (or a transitional sentence to the paragraph that follows)

A good paragraph is usually 4-6 sentences long. As a general rule, avoid single-sentence paragraphs. If your paragraphs run longer than a page, you are probably straining the reader - look for a logical place to make a break or reorganise the material.



A good paragraph is characterized by:



A: Unity (content) – focus on one area

- State the main idea of the paragraph in a clearly constructed topic sentence.
- Make sure each supporting sentence is related to the central thought.
- Consider adding a concluding sentence which relates to the issue/question raised in topic sentence

A good paragraph is characterized by:



B: Coherence (form) – connect together logically

- Arrange ideas in a clear, logical order.
- Provide appropriate transitions to the subsequent paragraph. Repeat key nouns and be consistent with pronouns.

A good paragraph is characterized by:



C: Adequate development

- Develop your paragraphs with specific details and examples.



What is the purpose of each of the sentences in this paragraph?



¹Population ageing places sustained pressure on public finances because it changes the ratio of contributors to claimants. ²Pension and healthcare systems in most developed economies are funded on a pay-as-you-go basis, meaning that current workers finance the benefits of current retirees. ³In Japan, the share of the population aged 65 and over has risen from roughly 12% in 1990 to close to 30% today, while the working-age population has shrunk in absolute terms. ⁴This shift matters less because of the number of older people itself than because of the shrinking base supporting them: each retiree is now funded by fewer contributors than a generation ago. ⁵The fiscal consequences are therefore structural rather than temporary, which suggests that adjustments to contribution rates alone are unlikely to be sufficient.

What is the purpose of each of the sentences in this paragraph?



¹Population ageing places sustained pressure on public finances because it changes the ratio of contributors to claimants. TOPIC SENTENCE ²Pension and healthcare systems in most developed economies are funded on a pay-as-you-go basis, meaning that current workers finance the benefits of current retirees. EXPLANATION ³In Japan, the share of the population aged 65 and over has risen from roughly 12% in 1990 to close to 30% today, while the working-age population has shrunk in absolute terms. EVIDENCE ⁴This shift matters less because of the number of older people itself than because of the shrinking base supporting them: each retiree is now funded by fewer contributors than a generation ago. COMMENTARY ON EVIDENCE ⁵The fiscal consequences are therefore structural rather than temporary, which suggests that adjustments to contribution rates alone are unlikely to be sufficient. CONCLUDING SENTENCE

Topic sentences



A strong topic sentence usually:

- States the main claim or focus of the paragraph.
- Relates clearly to the essay question/thesis.
- Is specific enough to predict what the paragraph will discuss.
- Often contains an argument or controlling idea, not just a topic.
- Is not simply a signpost ("This essay will discuss...") or a fact with no clear point.

Are these topic sentences effective? Why/Why not?



1. This paragraph will discuss the effects of an ageing population on healthcare systems.
2. Population ageing is a global phenomenon.
3. Japan's healthcare spending has increased in recent decades.
4. The rise in Japanese healthcare spending since 2000 reflects the ageing of the population rather than any increase in the cost of treating each patient.
5. Migration is a very important topic in demography today.
6. In 2015, more than a million people crossed the Mediterranean into Europe.
7. Explanations of the 2015 migration surge divide over whether it was driven primarily by conditions in sending countries or by shifts in European policy.
8. First this section will define population ageing, and then it will examine its consequences.
9. China's one-child policy is routinely blamed for the country's current age structure, but the sharpest fall in Chinese fertility preceded the policy by roughly a decade.
10. Replacement fertility is conventionally set at 2.1 births per woman, though the figure is an artefact of low-mortality conditions and misleads where child mortality remains high.

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Adequate but could be improved



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Which topic sentence is best for this paragraph and why?



In many countries, fertility rates have declined while the average age at which people have their first child has increased, contributing to a steady rise in the median age of the population. According to the United Nations, global fertility has fallen from approximately five children per woman in 1950 to around 2.2 today, while life expectancy has increased significantly due to advances in healthcare, nutrition, and living standards. As a result, populations are ageing rapidly, particularly in developed economies and an increasing number of middle-income countries.

Demographic projections indicate that this trend will continue over the coming decades, with older adults accounting for an increasingly larger share of the global population.

Topic Sentence Options

- A. Demographic trends are reshaping population structures around the world.
- B. Population ageing has become a major demographic trend driven by declining fertility and increasing life expectancy.
- C. Many countries are facing a range of social and economic challenges.

Which topic sentence is best for this paragraph and why?



- B is the best option because it identifies the paragraph's central idea (population ageing) and introduces the two key causes (declining fertility and increasing life expectancy) that are explained in the paragraph.
- A is less effective because it is too broad. "Demographic trends" and "population structures" could refer to migration, urbanisation, mortality, or other demographic changes, whereas the paragraph focuses specifically on population ageing.
- C is inappropriate because it is overly general and introduces a new focus (social and economic challenges) that is not discussed in the paragraph.

Topic sentences should create an essay narrative. Read the topic sentences below:



Essay Question: To what extent do demographic changes create challenges for governments?

1. Demographic changes create challenges for governments because ageing populations increase demand for healthcare and pensions.
2. Demographic changes also create challenges for governments because falling birth rates may reduce the size of the future workforce.
3. However, some demographic changes can help governments address these challenges, particularly when migration increases labour supply.
4. Nevertheless, demographic changes continue to create significant challenges for governments because migration cannot fully offset ageing populations and low birth rates.
5. Overall, demographic changes create substantial challenges for governments, although their impact depends partly on policy responses.

Questions:

- What is the writer's overall argument?
- How does each paragraph contribute to answering the question?
- Could you predict the conclusion after reading the first four topic sentences?

Can you put these topic sentences into a logical order?



Essay Question: Should governments be concerned about falling birth rates?

- A. However, governments should not be concerned about falling birth rates exclusively, as some demographic and technological changes may reduce the need for population growth.
- B. Falling birth rates are a reason governments should be concerned because they can lead to a shrinking workforce.
- C. As a result, governments should be concerned about falling birth rates because a smaller workforce may slow economic growth and increase pressure on public finances.
- D. Therefore, although there are some potential benefits, governments should be concerned about falling birth rates because the economic risks are likely to be greater.
- E. Nevertheless, some researchers argue that governments should not be overly concerned about falling birth rates because slower population growth can reduce pressure on resources and public services.

Can you put these topic sentences into a logical order?



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- E. Nevertheless, some researchers argue that governments should not be overly concerned about falling birth rates because slower population growth can reduce pressure on resources and public services.

Suggested Order

B → C → E → A → D

Questions

- Which topic sentence answers the essay question most directly?
- Where does the writer introduce a counterargument?
- How does each topic sentence build on the previous one?
- If you read only the topic sentences, can you understand the entire argument?

Topic sentences should have a clear link to the essay question



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2. Demographic changes also create challenges for governments because falling birth rates may reduce the size of the future workforce.
3. However, some demographic changes can help governments address these challenges, particularly when migration increases labour supply.
4. Nevertheless, demographic changes continue to create significant challenges for governments because migration cannot fully offset ageing populations and low birth rates.
5. Overall, demographic changes create substantial challenges for governments, although their impact depends partly on policy responses.

Highlight words that echo the essay question in these topic sentences



Essay Question: Should governments be concerned about falling birth rates?

1. Falling birth rates are a reason governments should be concerned because they can lead to a shrinking workforce.
2. As a result, governments should be concerned about falling birth rates because a smaller workforce may slow economic growth and increase pressure on public finances.
3. Nevertheless, some researchers argue that governments should not be overly concerned about falling birth rates because slower population growth can reduce pressure on resources and public services.
4. However, governments should not be concerned about falling birth rates exclusively, as some demographic and technological changes may reduce the need for population growth.
5. Therefore, although there are some potential benefits, governments should be concerned about falling birth rates because the economic risks are likely to be greater.

Which works best for the essay question “How is urbanisation changing societies?” Why?



Essay A

1. Urbanisation is creating new economic opportunities for many people.
2. Rapid population growth in urban areas is placing increasing pressure on housing and public services.
3. Urbanisation is also changing societies by altering patterns of social interaction and community life.
4. Taken together, these developments suggest that urbanisation is changing society in both positive and negative ways.

Essay B

1. Urbanisation is accelerating in many regions of the world.
2. Some of the world's largest cities are now located in Asia.
3. Governments have introduced a range of policies to manage urban growth.
4. Future rates of urbanisation are likely to vary between countries.
5. Urbanisation is an important demographic trend.

Look at the essay you wrote on Week 1 Friday:



1. How many paragraphs did it have?
1. What was the topic of each paragraph?
1. Do your paragraphs have topic sentences? If so, are they effective or could they have been improved?
1. If you just read your topic sentences (without reading the rest of the essay), do they create a clear narrative?

Choose 1-2 paragraphs to look at in detail



1. How many sentences do they have?
1. What is the function of each sentence?
1. Do the sentences link in a clear and logical way, or could this be improved?
1. Overall, how effective is your paragraphing? What, if anything, do you need to work on in this area?

Bonus Task



Some governments have introduced financial incentives to raise birth rates. Use the data below to write a paragraph arguing either that such policies are likely to be effective, or that they are not.

Country	Total Fertility Rate *	Notable Policy
South Korea	0.75	Large cash bonuses and housing support since the 2000s
Hungary	1.5	Tax exemptions and subsidised loans for larger families
France	1.7	Long-standing childcare provision and family allowances
Sweden	1.5	Generous, flexible parental leave shared between parents

* Replacement rate is 2.1

Additional points:

- South Korea has spent heavily over roughly two decades while its fertility rate has continued to fall.
- Hungary saw a modest rise from a very low base after policies were introduced, though the causes are disputed.
- France's relatively high rate is usually attributed to sustained childcare infrastructure rather than one-off payments.